

Is a Business Degree Worth It in the AI Era?

The already-in-it guide — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, and what to do from where you already are.

7.6

AI EXPOSURE · BUSINESS ANALYST / COORDINATOR
where 10 is most at risk

For anyone already in it — in the degree, or job-hunting.



Before you read this

The choice is already made — you're in a business degree, or out of one and into the job hunt. So this guide skips the "should you study business" question and goes straight to the one that's actually live: given where you already are, what do you do about it?

It's written to you directly — whether you are the one in it, or a parent reading on their behalf. Where it says "you," a parent can simply read "them"; the moves are the same either way.

What this is. A facts document, not a pep talk. It sets out what's known about where business sits in an AI economy, where the evidence is contested, and where we might be wrong — and then what to actually do from here.

The good news, up front. Already in it is not too late — not close. Business isn't one destination, it's a wide spread of them, from 4.9 to 7.6, and almost none of your exposure is fixed yet. Where you land inside that range is decided mostly by moves still in front of you. The second half of this guide is those moves.

One honest note. Business is the most-taken degree in the country, which makes it the default — the thing people pick when nothing else stood out. If that was the reason, it's worth knowing now, because it changes nothing about the degree and everything about how deliberately you have to steer. The default-choosers are heavily over-represented among the underemployed. Steering on purpose is exactly what this guide is for.

The short answer

A general business degree with no specialization, no placement and no analytical depth is one of the weaker bets in this index. The versions that work are specific — and the good news is that specific is still available to you from almost any starting point.

Business analyst and coordinator roles score 7.6 out of 10. General management with real accountability scores 4.9.

And here is the thing that separates business from every other career we score: look at what's missing from that range. Nothing sits below 4.9. Every other profession in this index has a

protected core. Business has a protected ceiling — which means the work now is climbing toward it, not just landing anywhere.

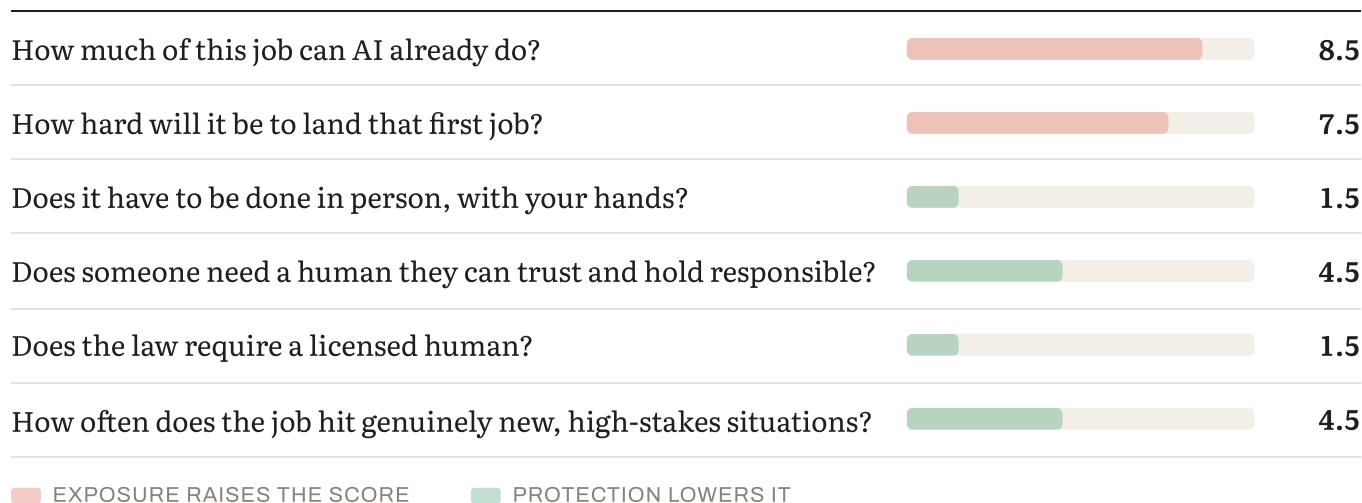
The scores

DESTINATION	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
General management / P&L ownership	4.2	4.5	4.9	+0.7	Moderate
Supply chain & operations	4.3	4.6	5.0	+0.7	Moderate
HR / people	4.7	5.0	5.3	+0.6	Moderate
Project management	5.3	5.7	6.1	+0.8	Moderate–High
Business analyst / coordinator	6.2	7.0	7.6	+1.4	High

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around 5.5, bedside nursing scores 2.8, a service electrician scores 2.5, and entry-level software development scores 8.1.

Read the table this way: the spread is 2.7 points, which is narrower than law's or medicine's. That sounds reassuring and isn't. The range is narrow because the whole field sits in the middle — there is no safe end to retreat to. Your job, from here, is to move up the table, not to hope the table moves.

Why business scores the way it does — the six factors



Here's how a business analyst answers them — the exposed end, and where most graduates start. Knowing *why* the entry roles score 7.6 is what tells you which way to move.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

More than almost any non-technical office role we score.

Report building and dashboard maintenance. Deck assembly. Market and competitor research. Process documentation. Requirements gathering and write-up. Meeting notes, trackers, status reporting.

The pattern here is unusually clean, and it's worth stating plainly: **almost everything on that list is what an entry-level business graduate was hired to do.**

What resists: owning a number and answering for it, managing people, negotiating with someone whose interests differ from yours, and deciding what should be measured in the first place. Those are the things to be building toward.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Bad, and worse than the automation alone would suggest — because two forces are compressing the same rung.

The first is automation. Analyst programs, coordinator roles and junior project management are precisely the automatable layer. Firms that once hired three graduates to build the reports now hire one experienced person with tooling.

The second has nothing to do with AI, and our framework doesn't measure it: **plain oversupply.** Business is the most-conferred bachelor's degree in the United States. There is no licensing body capping entry, no clinical placement bottleneck, no accreditation constraint on numbers.

The evidence section below covers what the labor market data actually shows, because it's the most important evidence in this guide.

The way through the Catch-22 isn't to wait for the entry rung to come back — it may not. It's to enter beside it: through a placement that substitutes for the vanishing analyst years, through a protected lane rather than the generic one, and with a result you can point to instead of a CV that reads like everyone else's. That's a set of concrete moves, not a hope, and the career-hunting checklist later in this guide lays them out.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

Effectively none of it.

Business work is meetings, documents, spreadsheets and decisions. There is no physical component to protect it — and unlike law or accounting, no licensing to compensate. The exception is operations and supply chain, which touch real-world constraints, and score marginally better for it.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

At the top, genuinely. At the bottom, not at all.

A general manager owns a P&L and answers for it. That accountability is real, it attaches to a person, and it's the main thing holding the top of this profession at 4.9 rather than 6.5.

An analyst produces work someone else presents. The protection in business exists — but it is entirely seniority-dependent, and a graduate has none of it. Which means the fastest way to become protected is to get closer to something you answer for.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

No. Nothing.

This is business's defining structural weakness, and it is permanent. No professional body controls entry. No statute reserves any management activity to a qualified person. Compare accounting, where the audit signature is a legal monopoly, or nursing, where scope-of-practice rules and staffing ratios are written into law.

Business has no floor beneath it. Whatever protection you have, you earned personally. That is a burden and an opening at once — nothing is handed to you, but nothing is closed to you either.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

At senior level often; at junior level rarely.

A managing director deciding whether to enter a market faces genuine novelty. An analyst producing a requested dashboard does not. The distance between those two is the distance you're trying to close.

What the trend shows

Business analyst: 6.2 → 7.0 → 7.6. Up 1.4 points in three years.

General management: 4.2 → 4.5 → 4.9. Up 0.7.

Every destination moved, and none moved slowly. That is unusual. In most professions we score, the protected end barely shifts — bedside nursing moved 0.7, surgery 0.3. In business, even the most protected destination moved 0.7, because there is nothing structural holding it still.

The gap widened from 2.0 points to 2.7. The ladder's top is holding better than its bottom, but the whole ladder is drifting — which is why standing still on the bottom rung is the one thing not to do.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Human trust / accountability	Real at senior level	Durable	Someone must answer for the number. Socially and commercially rooted.
Judgment under novelty	Real at senior level	Eroding	Decision support is improving; genuine strategic novelty is not automating.
Regulatory / licensing	None	n/a	No license exists and none is coming.
Physical / embodied	None	n/a	Except in operations and supply chain, which is why those score marginally better.

The honest read. Business has two of the four protections, both of them seniority-dependent, and neither inherited from the profession. A doctor is protected on day one by a license. A manager is protected only once they have something to be accountable for.

That is the central fact this guide turns on: the protection is real, but it's earned, and the whole game is getting to it faster than the automation reaches you.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Building the report	Deciding what the report should measure
Running the analysis	Interrogating an analysis that arrived pre-built
Coordinating the project	Owning whether it delivers
Producing the deck	Standing behind what it argues
Learning the business by assembling its numbers	Learning it... some other way, still being worked out

The last row is the real problem. Generations of managers learned how a business actually worked by building its reports — you cannot assemble a P&L pack for two years without understanding the company. That was tedious, and it was also the education. Nobody has yet built a replacement. Which means the people who go out of their way to understand the business — not just produce its outputs — have an edge that's about to get scarcer.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Accountability for an outcome** — the willingness to own a number publicly. The single most protective attribute in this field. 2. **Managing people** — hiring, developing, and having difficult conversations. Barely touched by any of this. 3. **Negotiation** — dealing with someone whose interests genuinely differ from yours. 4. **Deciding what to measure** — the judgment upstream of the analysis, rather than the analysis itself. 5. **Verification** — knowing when a generated analysis is confidently wrong, which requires understanding the business well enough to smell it.

Notably absent: producing decks, building models and assembling reports. These were the traditional markers of a strong graduate hire and are the fastest-depreciating things on the list. If your current value is mostly on that second list, the work is to shift it onto the first.

And underneath all five, two traits the score can't grade: **curiosity and adaptability**. The specific tools will turn over many times across a career — the people who compound are the ones who stay genuinely curious and re-tool fastest, rather than defending the one way of working they learned. In a field with no license and no fixed toolkit, that flexibility is itself a form of protection, and it's the thing employers are increasingly hiring for: the trajectory, not the current skill set.

The evidence that matters most — and it isn't about AI

This is the section to sit with first, because it's the strongest data in this guide and it comes from an independent source.

The **Federal Reserve Bank of New York** tracks labor market outcomes for recent graduates. As of Q1 2026:

- Recent graduate unemployment stood at **5.7%**, against a national rate of 4.2%
- **Underemployment — working in a job that doesn't require a degree — sat at 41.5%**
- Recent-graduate unemployment has now exceeded the national rate for five consecutive years, something that was almost unheard of between 1990 and 2018

A separate Burning Glass Institute and Strada study found **52% of bachelor's degree holders were underemployed a year after graduation** — and, importantly, that those who start underemployed tend to stay that way. That last point is the one that matters most for someone job-hunting right now: **the first role is stickier than it feels, so aiming it well is worth real effort**.

Now the comparison that should shape how you aim. Nursing has the lowest underemployment rate of any major the New York Fed tracks, at **12.8%**. Against a graduate average of 41.5%.

That gap is not about intelligence, effort or prestige. It is about whether a degree points at a specific job that legally requires it. Nursing does. General business does not — which is exactly why the aiming is on you, and why it's worth doing deliberately.

This is why we say business's problem is not primarily AI. Automation is compressing the entry rung, and it's real. But it's arriving on top of a graduate market where four in ten degree-holders are already working in jobs that don't need a degree — and business, as the most-conferred degree in the country with no cap on numbers, sits at the center of that.

Our framework measures automation exposure. It cannot see oversupply. **For business specifically, the thing we can't measure may matter more than the thing we can, and we'd**

rather say so than pretend the score is the whole picture.

Other things worth knowing

What's genuinely good about it

The destinations are genuinely good. General management, operations leadership and commercial roles are well paid, intellectually varied, and carry real autonomy. Business and finance occupations are projected to grow 6–7% — solid, if unspectacular.

What people in these roles report as rewarding:

- **Breadth** — few careers touch as many parts of an organization
- **Visible impact** — decisions produce results you can see
- **Pace of progression** — competence advances faster here than in credentialed professions
- **Optionality** — the skills transfer across industries and geographies more easily than most
- **A realistic route to ownership** — business is one of the few paths where starting your own is a normal outcome rather than an exotic one

And one genuine advantage over the licensed professions: nobody can stop you. There's no board, no registration, no scope of practice. The same absence that removes the floor also removes the ceiling — you can climb as fast as you can prove yourself.

What's genuinely hard about it

Getting the first job — the dominant risk, covered above.

Proving value without a credential. A nurse is a nurse. A business graduate is a claim that has to be substantiated repeatedly, especially early. This is why demonstrable results matter so much here.

The middle is crowded. Progression from analyst to manager is the bottleneck, and it's where the automation is landing hardest — which is the argument for getting to something you own sooner rather than waiting your turn.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Business tends to reward people who:

- **Are comfortable being accountable in public** — this is the core protective trait
- **Genuinely like organizations** — how they work, why they fail, what makes people move
- **Can be useful without being told what to do.** The single biggest differentiator early on.
- **Are commercially curious** — interested in why something makes money, not just that it does

It's harder for people who want clear structure and defined tasks (that's exactly the automating layer), who need a credential to feel qualified, or who chose it because nothing else appealed. If the last one is you, it isn't a reason to quit — it's a reason to pick a lane deliberately now, which is what the rest of this does.

What else is moving this market

Oversupply is the dominant force, and it's structural rather than cyclical. Nothing caps the number of business graduates.

Skills-based hiring is being announced more than practiced. A Burning Glass and Harvard Business School analysis found that removing degree requirements from postings hasn't meaningfully changed who gets hired.

Internships have become the actual filter. NACE's employer survey rates internship experience **4.5 out of 5** as a hiring factor — the highest-rated item. **In a field with no license, the placement is the closest thing to one** — which is why, if you're still in the degree, it's the single most valuable thing left to chase.

The AI-native advantage — what it actually looks like

The situation: business is where AI adoption is fastest, because there's nothing slowing it down — no regulator, no licensing body, no safety case to make. That cuts both ways. The exposure is higher, and so is the opportunity for someone who can direct it. Being already in it, close to the work, is a real advantage here — you can build this fluency inside a live internship or first job, which is exactly where it counts.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE BUSINESS GRADUATE LOOKS LIKE

1. Verify. Knowing when a generated analysis is confidently wrong. This requires understanding the business well enough to smell an implausible number — which is exactly the understanding the old report-building years used to produce.

2. Frame. Deciding what question is worth asking. The analysis is now cheap; knowing what to analyze is not.

3. Automate visibly. Being the person who rebuilds a manual process and can show what it saved. In a field with no credential, demonstrable results are the credential.

4. Communicate under scrutiny. Standing behind a recommendation when someone senior pushes back.

5. Own something measurable, early. The whole guide points at accountability. Anything that puts you closer to a number you answer for moves you up the scale.

All five are available to you now — not after some future qualification. Turning them into concrete moves is the rest of this guide.

Where a business degree can take you later

The good news is genuine breadth: general management, operations, commercial and sales leadership, HR, project and program delivery, consulting, entrepreneurship, and finance-adjacent roles.

The caveat that runs through this index applies with unusual force here. In most professions, moving away from the core raises exposure. In business there is no core to move away from — so the question isn't distance from the center, it's proximity to accountability. Roles where someone owns a number score better. Roles that support other people's numbers score worse. That's the whole map, and it's the compass for every choice below.

Repositioning from here

The program-selection stage is behind you. The useful questions now are different — and the good news bears repeating: almost none of your exposure is fixed yet. Business is a 2.7-point spread from 4.9 to 7.6, and where you land inside it is decided mostly by things still in front of you.

If you're still in the degree

Three levers, in order of leverage.

1. The specialization is the whole game. A general business degree is the exposed one — it's the row that scores worst in this entire guide. The protected destinations — general management with P&L accountability (4.9), operations and supply chain (5.0), HR (5.3) — are reached by concentration, not by the generic core. If you haven't committed to a track, this is the single highest-leverage decision left in the degree. If you have, hold it up against the scores above and ask honestly whether it points at *accountability* or at *reporting*.

2. Quantitative depth, while it's still free. The analyst and coordinator roles that score 7.6 are the report-builders — pattern-work on structured data, first in line for automation. The same aptitude aimed one level up — owning the model rather than running it, deciding what to measure rather than compiling it — is the judgment layer that ages well. Every quantitative elective you can still take (statistics, econometrics, experimentation) is a step from the exposed end toward the protected one, and it is far cheaper to acquire now than to bolt on later.

3. Accountability, earlier than feels comfortable. The through-line of this whole index is that roles where someone owns an outcome score better than roles that feed one — and that doesn't have to wait for graduation. A co-op with real P&L exposure, running an actual budget in a student venture or society, an internship where you carry a number rather than support one: that is the experience that separates the protected ceiling from the exposed floor, and in a field with no license, it's the closest thing to one.

If you've graduated and you're job-hunting

Here the title on the offer matters more than it looks, because the most common early-career business titles are also the most exposed.

- **"Business analyst" and "coordinator" are the 7.6.** They're the default graduate destinations and the automating layer at once. Taking one isn't fatal — but take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.
- **Aim at operations and supply chain (5.0).** More protected, closer to real-world constraints, and chronically under-applied-to — which means less competition, not more.
- **Attach to a domain, not "business in general."** Business paired with healthcare, energy, logistics or a regulated industry inherits that field's protection. "Open to anything" aims straight at the exposed middle.
- **Chase the number.** Anything with a P&L line, a target, a team or a budget attached moves you up the scale — even small, even at a smaller company, where accountability tends to arrive years sooner.

The AI-native move, from where you stand

You can't undo the last two years, but you can be the graduate who directs these tools rather than competes with them. The five capabilities above — verify, frame, automate visibly, communicate under scrutiny, own something measurable — are all available right now, inside a current internship or a first job. The most powerful for someone already in it is the third: **be the person who rebuilds a manual process and can show what it saved.** In a field with no credential, a demonstrable result is the credential — and it's one you can start building this term, not after some future qualification.

The career-hunting checklist

The analysis tells you where the exposure is. This is what to do about it — the part that's actually in your hands. Most of the protection in business is built here, in these habits, rather than handed to you. The first list is for anyone still in the degree; the second is for the job hunt itself.

During the degree — build what can't be automated

- **Lock in a specialization with structural protection.** Operations, supply chain, or genuine quantitative depth over general management studies. The generic core is the exposed lane.
- **Treat the placement as non-negotiable.** In a field with no license, the internship is the closest thing to one, and the single strongest signal you can carry. One isn't enough — do two if the program allows it.
- **Own one real, measurable thing before you graduate.** A budget, a small venture, a society's P&L, a project whose outcome is yours. Evidence is the credential.
- **Get fluent with AI as a worker, not a shortcut.** Be able to direct it, catch it when it's confidently wrong, and point to a process you rebuilt and what it saved. That's the story that lands in an interview.
- **Feed curiosity and adaptability on purpose.** The tools will turn over repeatedly; the person who re-tools fastest compounds. Staying genuinely interested in how organizations work is what keeps that engine running.
- **Keep the frame wide.** Properly vet adjacent paths — operations, supply chain, a domain pairing, even the trades — before ruling them out. The most crowded lane is almost always the default one.

During the job hunt — aim, don't just apply

- **Target the protected lanes on purpose.** Ownership tracks, operations, supply chain, a domain-paired role — not "business analyst, open to anything," which points straight at the 7.6.
 - **Read the title, not just the offer.** "Analyst" and "coordinator" are the automating layer. If you take one, take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.
 - **Don't grab a job just because it's on offer in an exposed lane.** A role being available doesn't make it safe. An employer still running a large analyst intake may simply be behind the curve — and that's exactly the rung that gets cut first once they catch up. Availability today can be a lagging indicator, not a green light.
 - **Prefer the number, and the smaller room.** A role with a P&L line, a target, or a team — often at a smaller organization — puts you close to accountability years sooner than supporting someone else's work at a big name.
 - **Ask the employer where AI is heading in the role.** How they answer reveals whether they're building the job around these tools or waiting to be forced to. You want the former; it's the difference between a role that grows and one that's quietly being hollowed out.
 - **Weigh the trajectory over the starting salary.** A slightly lower-paid role that builds ownership and AI-fluency beats a higher-paid seat in a lane that's being automated underneath you.
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Go deeper — further reading

- **The Labor Market for Recent College Graduates** — Federal Reserve Bank of New York. The single most useful link in this guide, and free. Unemployment and underemployment by major, updated quarterly, from a central bank rather than an industry body. Look up business against nursing and engineering to see the aiming problem in one screen.
- **Talent Disrupted: Underemployment and the Value of a College Degree** — Burning Glass Institute and Strada Institute. Finds 52% of graduates underemployed a year out, and — more importantly for you — that starting underemployed tends to be sticky rather than temporary.
- **Class of 2026: A depressed hires rate is the cause of labor market weakness for young graduates** — Economic Policy Institute. A careful counterweight to AI-driven explanations: the hires rate has fallen broadly, which suggests a cyclical component alongside the structural one — and cyclical means it can also recover.

The counterargument — read this one:

- **Too many college graduates flood the white-collar job market** — Quartz.

The argument against our score is that we're attributing to AI what is really a supply problem. On this reading, business graduate outcomes were deteriorating well before generative AI existed, driven by the sheer number of degrees conferred and by employers raising requirements — and our 7.6 is measuring a labor market condition rather than a technological one.

Where we land: we think this is substantially correct, and we've said so above rather than hiding it. Business is the field where our framework is least sufficient on its own. What we'd add is that the two forces compound rather than compete — oversupply meant graduates already needed a differentiator, and automation removed the rung where they used to acquire one. Treat our score as one input alongside the New York Fed's underemployment data, not as a complete account.

Bottom line

Business is the field where what you do with the degree matters more than the degree itself — and by a wider margin than anywhere else in this index. That's the whole reason being already in it is not a problem: the decisive moves were always going to happen from here.

The destinations are good. General management, operations and commercial leadership are well-paid, varied, and protected by real accountability.

The route is the challenge, and it's a double one. Automation removed the entry rung, and it arrived on top of a graduate market where 41.5% of degree-holders are already underemployed. Business has a protected ceiling and no protected core — which means every bit of protection has to be earned, starting from a position of having none.

So the useful advice isn't a verdict on the degree — it's a direction. Concentrate into operations or genuine quantitative depth rather than staying general. Get accountable for something measurable as early as you can. Aim the job hunt at protected lanes and read the title, not just the offer. And build real AI fluency now, inside whatever role you're in, because that's the differentiator this field rewards fastest.

And one honest thing, if you're in business because nothing else appealed: that's the single strongest predictor of a poor outcome in this field, and it has nothing to do with AI. It isn't a reason to abandon the degree — it's the reason to steer it hard, deliberately, starting now.

Business rewards people who are genuinely interested in how organizations work. The good news is that interest can be built as easily from the inside as chosen from the outside.

Questions worth sitting with

Whether you're the one in the degree or a parent thinking it through, these are the conversations that move the needle now. Read "you" as whoever the decision is about.

Where you actually stand

1. Which specialization or track are you on — and does it point at *accountability* (owning a number) or at *reporting* (producing one)? 2. Looking at the score table, which destination are you currently pointed at, and is it the one you'd choose on purpose? 3. Is there anything you own end-to-end right now — a budget, a project's outcome, a real result — or only things you contribute to? If it's the latter, what's the nearest way to change that?

The move from here

4. What's the single most protected role you could realistically aim for from where you are now, and what would make you a credible candidate for it? 5. If you're still studying: what's the most quantitative elective still open to you, and is there a reason not to take it? 6. If you're job-hunting: are you aiming at a protected lane on purpose, or applying to whatever's open? Name the three roles you're actually chasing.

The AI question, practically

7. Of the five capabilities — verify, frame, automate visibly, communicate under scrutiny, own something measurable — which one could you visibly demonstrate within the next few months? 8. Can you point to a single process you've rebuilt or improved with these tools and say what it saved? If not, what would be the easiest one to start with?

Testing it against reality

9. **The most valuable single action:** find someone 3–5 years into a business career and ask what they actually did in year one, and whether that job still exists in the same form. 10. If the first offer that comes is a "business analyst" or "coordinator" role, what's your plan — take it as a

deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, or hold out for something closer to a number? Decide before the offer, not after.

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation, not a guarantee or a prediction. For business specifically, we've flagged that our framework measures automation exposure and cannot see graduate oversupply — and that the second may matter more than the first.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Business & Management

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

1. The formula

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Risk} = & 0.35 \times \text{Automatability} \\ & + 0.15 \times \text{EntryErosion} \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Physical}) \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Trust}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Regulatory}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Judgment}) \end{aligned}$$

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-eight careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel.
3–4	Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence.
5–6	A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup.
7–8	A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role.
9–10	Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard.

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated.
3–4	Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives.
5–6	Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced.
7–8	Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone.
9–10	The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer.

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Fully screen-based. Location-independent.
3–4	Occasional presence; the core work is not physical.
5–6	Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions.
7–8	Substantially physical, with some variability of setting.
9–10	Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time.

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No license exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent, where being wrong is costly?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

GENERAL MANAGEMENT / P&L OWNERSHIP — 4.9 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.0	4.7	5.7	1.99
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.0	3.4	3.8	0.57
Physical / embodied	15%	2.5	2.5	2.5	1.12
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.5	8.5	8.5	0.22
Regulatory / licensing	10%	2.0	2.0	2.0	0.8
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.0	8.0	8.0	0.2
				Total	4.92 → 4.9

SUPPLY CHAIN & OPERATIONS — 5.0 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.1	4.7	5.7	1.99
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.2	3.6	4.0	0.6
Physical / embodied	15%	3.5	3.5	3.5	0.97
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.38
Regulatory / licensing	10%	2.0	2.0	2.0	0.8
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.25
				Total	5.0 → 5.0

HR / PEOPLE — 5.3 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.0	4.7	5.4	1.89
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.0	4.4	4.8	0.72
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.38
Regulatory / licensing	10%	2.5	2.5	2.5	0.75
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.0	7.0	7.0	0.3
				Total	5.31 → 5.3

PROJECT MANAGEMENT — 6.1 (MODERATE-HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.1	5.0	5.8	2.03
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.0	5.6	6.2	0.93
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	6.0	6.0	6.0	0.6
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.5	1.5	1.5	0.85
Judgment under novelty	10%	6.0	6.0	6.0	0.4
				Total	6.08 → 6.1

BUSINESS ANALYST / COORDINATOR — 7.6 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.9	7.0	8.5	2.97
Entry-path erosion	15%	6.5	7.0	7.5	1.12
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	4.5	4.5	4.5	0.82
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.5	1.5	1.5	0.85
Judgment under novelty	10%	4.5	4.5	4.5	0.55
				Total	7.6 → 7.6

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

General management / P&L ownership

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	4.0	3.0	2.35	4.2
2025	4.7	3.4	2.35	4.5
Fall 2026	5.7	3.8	2.35	4.9

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed **+0.59** and entry-path erosion **+0.12**, for a total of **+0.7** points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labor market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.
- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.